

job for the fourth time. But it took him almost a month to get a cabinet going, and five more months to grant berths to 10 turncoats. The heartburn among party old-timers at the sight of new converts taking away all the fish and loaves was more than evident. Yediyurappa had himself briefly rebelled, forming his own party between 2012-14, and his loyalists formed another factional layer in the state BJP, which the party tolerated owing to his mass popularity. But not for long. BSY was eased out in July 2021. And that risky manoeuvre involved deploying the next arrow in the BJP's quiver: the caste and community calculus, another perennial reality of Indian politics.

THE SOCIAL RAINBOW

One part of the BJP's expansionism is purely geographical. Witness the carefully woven fabric of names it nominated to the Rajya Sabha on July 6: sprint legend P.T. Usha is from Kerala; music savant Ilaiyaraja from Tamil Nadu; V. Vijayendra Prasad, the screenwriter of blockbusters like *Baahubali* and *RRR*, is Telugu; philanthropist Veerendra Heggade from Karnataka. The South still looms as unconquered territory for the saffron party, and symbolism helps. But caste and community present to the BJP a complex kaleidoscope that it needs to negotiate with some care and caution. Its calculation is simple. Hyper-Hindutva has ensured that the 14 per cent Muslim vote is largely alienated from it, hence it has to ensure that the 79.8 per cent Hindu vote is not further fragmented into caste and subcaste loyalties.

When it showed the door to BSY, the BJP knew he was an icon among the Lingayats. And it could not afford disaffection among them, since the other power-wielding caste of Karnataka, the Vokkaligas, were still largely with the JD(S). Thus it came to be that the sceptre was handed to community man Bommai, even if he was not old BJP stock. It was trading one risk for another, accepting the manageable one of inner-party factionalism in lieu of the greater disaster of collective community anger. This is at the root of the trouble Bommai finds himself in, with other Lingayat leaders like Nirani Murugesh, Arvind Bellad and Jagadish Shettar coveting his job and national general secretary B.L. Santhosh playing a parallel power centre. The old/ new dichotomy played out even in Tripura, where the change of guard in May saw heated exchanges between legislators and RSS old-timer Ram Prasad Paul—a rare show of dissent. But over and above its old iron-clad discipline, Nadda also points to the open channels that help mitigate any potential for conflict. "Regular communication happens with the new entrants," says the BJP president. "They are not treated as outsiders and are made part of the organisation's working without any discrimination. Gradually, they get accustomed to our culture. We ensure that they are assimilated and are always open and accessible for talks and discussions."

Uttar Pradesh provides a classic example of the BJP's mastery of the

"THE DECISION TO INDUCT SOMEONE IS TAKEN CONSCIOUSLY AND CAUTIOUSLY... EVALUATING THEIR SOCIAL STANDING, THEIR FOLLOWING, WHAT THEY CAN DO FOR THE PARTY"

—J.P. Nadda, *BJP president*



BANDEEP SINGH